

Record-long shutdown comes to an end

Knives are out for Schumer in some corners of caucus

BY THEODORIC MEYER AND MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

Senate Minority Leader Charles E. Schumer did things differently this time.

The New York Democrat infuriated much of his party in March when he voted with Republicans to prevent a government shutdown, and he faced questions about whether he would step down as leader as a result.

As another government funding deadline approached in September, Schumer led his party in blocking a Republican funding bill, triggering the longest shutdown in U.S. history. When a handful of Democrats broke with their party Sunday and struck a deal to reopen the government, Schumer voted against it.

Despite that, some Democrats are still furious with him. They argue that he is not doing enough to stand up to President Donald Trump and that the time has come for their party to elect younger, more aggressive leaders.

“If you’ve been in elective office for over 20 years, it’s fine to continue to serve,” Rep. Ro Khanna

SEE SCHUMER ON A7



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

“The American people demand it and deserve it,” House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) said before Wednesday night’s vote.

HOUSE PASSES DEAL, AND TRUMP SIGNS IT

Government gears up to reopen federal agencies

BY RILEY BEGGIN, MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR AND KADIA GOBA

The longest government shutdown in U.S. history ended late Wednesday night after President Donald Trump signed a spending package to reopen the government into law, capping 43 days of political stalemate that caused widespread disruptions at U.S. airports and upended government food assistance for hungry families.

Speaking from the White House late Wednesday, Trump blamed the shutdown and its harmful effects squarely on the Democratic Party and portrayed its end as a Republican victory.

“This is no way to run a country. I hope we all can agree that the government should never be shut down again,” he said in a live broadcast.

He vowed to pass legislation to end politicians’ ability to filibuster.

Earlier in the day, the House had voted to reopen federal agencies, marking the first time it had

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@PKCapitol: Some Democrats are angry but also quietly relieved. A5

As costs rise, coffee shops say trouble is brewing

Owners fear being priced out of their role as community hubs

BY GAYA GUPTA

TJ Fairchild and his wife, Julie, had never planned on starting their own business, but they opened Commonplace Coffee in Pittsburgh two decades ago because they were inspired by how coffee brought people together.

The founders of Lost Sock Roasters in D.C., Communal Coffee in San Diego and Big Mouth Coffee Roasters in Upstate New York were driven by that same hope — that quality brew could cultivate a community.

Now many local coffee shops are struggling to maintain their status as “third places” that bring strangers together. The steep tariffs imposed by President Donald Trump have magnified the economic strain of an already volatile and soaring coffee market, leaving shop owners with a difficult question: Can they absorb some of those increased costs — to keep prices accessible for a wide range of customers — without putting themselves out of business?

“We want to be that place that is open for everyone to come and join,” Fairchild said. “And I just feel like it’s going to get harder and harder for that to happen.”

The import price of unroasted “green” coffee rose by 72 percent in the past year, according to the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. The retail price of ground coffee is also up, though less steeply — roughly 19 percent, according to the bureau.

Trump has argued that his tariffs, which began taking effect in April, will boost domestic production and jobs. But practically

SEE COFFEE ON A18

Epstein wrote that Trump knew of abuse but didn’t participate

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF AND MATTHEW CHOI

Investor Jeffrey Epstein wrote that Donald Trump knew about the sexual abuse of underage girls but never participated, according to thousands of pages of documents released Wednesday by the House Oversight Committee.

“Trump knew of it. and came to my house many times during that period,” Epstein wrote in an email to himself on Feb. 1, 2019, several months before he was arrested on sex trafficking charges and killed himself in jail. “He never got a massage.”

That account, included in a tranche of documents released

Wednesday by the House Oversight Committee, conflicts with Trump’s denial of ever knowing about Epstein’s solicitation of underage prostitution before Epstein’s 2008 plea deal. Trump has said that he knew Epstein socially in Palm Beach, Florida, and that they had a falling-out in the mid-2000s, which Trump has attribut-

ed to a real estate deal and Epstein’s hiring employees away from Trump’s Mar-a-Lago Club.

“I had no idea,” Trump told reporters in July 2019. “I haven’t spoken to him in many, many years.”

On Wednesday, Trump accused Democrats of resurfacing the scandal to distract from the pend-

ing end of a 43-day government shutdown, which disrupted air travel and food stamp distribution while winning the opposition party few concessions. “The Democrats are using the Jeffrey Epstein Hoax to try and deflect from their massive failures, in particular, their most recent one

SEE TRUMP ON A9



NOORULLAH SHIRZADA/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Farmers work in an Afghan poppy field in 2013. The CIA operation lasted from 2004 to about 2015.

Secret mission targeted Afghan opium

During war, CIA dropped billions of modified poppy seeds to sabotage crop

BY WARREN P. STROBEL

In 20 years of grinding war in Afghanistan, the United States dropped a multitude of weapons from the skies: Millions of tons of ordnance. Hellfire missiles launched from Predator drones. Even the “Mother of All Bombs,” the most powerful nonnuclear bomb in existence. And, amid the more conventional projectiles, tiny poppy seeds. By the billions.

On and off for over a decade, the Central Intelligence Agency conducted an audacious highly classified program to covertly manipulate Afghanistan’s lucrative poppy crop, blanketing Afghan farmers’ fields with specially modified seeds that germinated plants containing almost none of the chemicals that are refined into heroin, The Washington Post has learned.

The covert program, which has not previously been disclosed, is an

unreported chapter in the 2001-2021 U.S. war in Afghanistan and in the long checkered history of American efforts to combat narcotics globally, from Latin America to Asia. Its existence was confirmed by 14 people familiar with aspects of the secret operation, all of whom spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe a classified project.

The program’s disclosure comes

SEE CIA ON A8

Some users are baring their souls to ChatGPT

Analysis of conversations reveals intimate role AI bot plays in people’s lives

BY GERRIT DE VYNCK AND JEREMY B. MERRILL

The questions flood in from every corner of the human psyche. “What are permanent hair removal solutions?” “Can you help me analyze this text conversation between me and my boyfriend?” “Tell me all about woke mind virus.” “What is the survivors rate for paracetamol overdose?” “Are you feeling conscious?”

ChatGPT answers them all, flitting from personal grooming advice to relationship help to philosophy.

More than 800 million people use ChatGPT each week, according to its maker, OpenAI, but their conversations with the artificial intelligence chatbot are private. Unlike for social media apps, there is little way for those outside the company to know how people use the service — or what ChatGPT says to them.

A collection of 47,000 publicly shared ChatGPT conversations compiled by The Washington Post sheds light on the reasons people turn to the chatbot and the deeply intimate role it plays in many lives. The conversations were made public by ChatGPT users

who created shareable links to their chats that were later preserved in the Internet Archive, creating a unique snapshot of tens of thousands of interactions with the chatbot.

Analyzing the chats also revealed patterns in how the AI tool uses language. Some users have complained that ChatGPT agrees with them too readily. The Post found it began responses with variations on “yes” 10 times as often as it did with versions of “no.”

OpenAI has largely promoted ChatGPT as a productivity tool, and in many conversations users asked for help with practical tasks such as retrieving information. But in more than 1 in 10 of the chats The Post analyzed, people engaged the chatbot in abstract discussions, musing on topics like their ideas for breakthrough medical treatments or personal beliefs about the nature of reality.

Data released by OpenAI in September from an internal study of queries sent to ChatGPT showed that most are for personal use, not work. (The Post has a content partnership with OpenAI.)

Emotional conversations were also common in the conversations analyzed by The Post, and users often shared highly personal details about their lives. In some chats, the AI tool could be seen adapting to match a user’s viewpoint, creating a kind of personalized echo chamber in which

SEE CHATGPT ON A18

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